MZUZU UNIVERSITY

FACULTY OF INFORMATION SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

DEPARTMENT OF ICT

COMM 1101: COMMUNICATION SKILLS 1

DATE: 14th September, 2017 **TIME :(2Hrs& 30 Mins)**

Instruction: Answer all Questions

Question 1

Read the passage below and summarise it in note-form.

Most people would agree that communication between two individuals should be simple. It's important to remember that there are differences between talking and communicating. When you communicate, you are successful in getting your point across to the person you're talking to. When we talk, we tend to erect barriers that hinder our ability to communicate. There are seven of these types of barriers to effective communication.

Physical barriers are easy to spot – doors that are closed, walls that are erected, and distance between people all work against the goal of effective communication. While most agree that people need their own personal areas in the workplace, setting up an office to remove physical barriers is the first step towards opening communication. Many professionals who work in industries that thrive on collaborative communication, such as architecture, purposefully design their workspaces around an "open office" plan. This layout eschews cubicles in favour of desks grouped around a central meeting space. While each individual has their own dedicated work space, there are no visible barriers to prevent collaboration with their co-workers. This encourages greater openness and frequently creates closer working bonds.

Perceptual barriers, in contrast, are internal. If you go into a situation thinking that the person you are talking to isn't going to understand or be interested in what you have to say, you may end up subconsciously sabotaging your effort to make your point. You will employ language that is sarcastic, dismissive, or even obtuse, thereby alienating your conversational partner. Think of movie scenarios in which someone yells clipped phrases at a person they believe is deaf. The person yelling ends up looking ridiculous while failing to communicate anything of substance.

Emotional barriers can be tough to overcome, but are important to put aside to engage in conversations. We are often taught to fear the words coming out of our own mouths, as in the phrase "anything you say can and will be used against you." Overcoming this fear is difficult, but necessary. The trick is to have full confidence in what you are saying and your qualifications in

saying it. People often pick up on insecurity. By believing in yourself and what you have to say, you will be able to communicate clearly without becoming overly involved in your emotions.

Cultural barriers are a result of living in an ever-shrinking world. Different cultures, whether they be a societal culture of a race or simply the work culture of a company, can hinder developed communication if two different cultures clash. In these cases, it is important to find a common ground to work from. In work situations, identifying a problem and coming up with a highly efficient way to solve it can quickly topple any cultural or institutional barriers. Quite simply, people like results.

Language barriers seem pretty self-inherent, but there are often hidden language barriers that we aren't always aware of. If you work in an industry that is heavy in jargon or technical language, care should be taken to avoid these words when speaking with someone from outside the industry. Without being patronizing, imagine explaining a situation in your industry to a child. How would you convey these concepts without relying on jargon? A clear, direct narrative is preferable to an incomprehensible slew of specialty terms.

Gender barriers have become less of an issue in recent years, but there is still the possibility for a man to misconstrue the words of a woman, or vice versa. Men and women tend to form their thoughts differently, and this must be taken into account when communicating. This difference has to do with how the brain of each sex is formed during gestation. In general, men are better at spatial visualization and abstract concepts such as math, while women excel at language-based thinking and emotional identification. However, successful professionals in highly competitive fields tend to have similar thought processes regardless of their gender.

Interpersonal barriers are what ultimately keep us from reaching out to each other and opening ourselves up, not just to be heard, but to hear others. Oddly enough, this can be the most difficult area to change. Some people spend their entire lives attempting to overcome a poor self-image or a series of deeply rooted prejudices about their place in the world. They are unable to form genuine connections with people because they have too many false perceptions blocking the way. Luckily, the cure for this is more communication. By engaging with others, we learn what our actual strengths and weaknesses are. This allows us to put forth our ideas in a clear, straightforward manner.

Communication is not a one-way street. To have others open up to you, you must be open yourself. By overcoming these barriers to communication, you can ensure that the statement you are making is not just heard, but also understood, by the person you are speaking with. In this way, you can be confident that your point has been expressed.

(15 marks)

Question 2

a) In your own words define 'communication'. **(3 marks)**

b) Mention elements of the communication process and explain the role each one plays in the process. **(7 marks)**

c) Explain **four** things you can do to enhance the quality of listening in a teaching and learning situation. **(4 marks)**

d) Give **two** advantages of oral communication over written communication. **(4 marks)**

(20 Marks)

Question 3

Read the passage below and answer the following questions.

I know all about bad schools, mean politicians, economic deprivation, and racism. Still, it occurs to me that one of the heaviest burdens black Americans – and black children in particular – have to bear is the handicap of definition: the question of what it means to be black.

Let mean explain quickly what I mean. If a basketball fan says that the Boston Celtics' Larry Bird plays "black," the fan intends it – and Bird probably accepts it – as a compliment. Tell pop singer Tom Jones he moves "black" and he might grin in appreciation. Say to Tina Marie or the Average White band that they sound "black" and they will thank you.

But name one pursuit, aside from athletics, entertainment or sexual performance in which a white practitioner will feel complimented to be told he does it "black" and he will sign for diction lessons. Tell a white reporter he writes "black" and he might sue you for slander.

What we have here is a tragically limited definition of blackness, and it isn't only white people who buy it.

Think of all the ways black children can put one another down with charges of "whiteness." For many of these children, hard study and hard work are "white." Trying to please a teacher might be criticized as acting "white". Speaking correct English is "white." Scrimping today in the interest of tomorrow's goals is "white." Educational toys and games are "white."

An incredible array of habits and attitudes that are conducive to success in business, in academia, in the non-entertainment professions are likely to be thought of as somehow "white." Even economic success, unless it involves such "black" undertakings as numbers banking, is defined as "white."

And the results are devastating. I wouldn't deny that blacks are often better entertainers and athletes. My point is the harm that comes from two narrow a definition of what is black.

One reason black youngsters tend to do better at basketball, for instance, is that they assume they can learn to do it well, and so they practice constantly to prove themselves right.

Wouldn't it be wonderful if we could infect black children with the notion that excellence is math is "black" rather than "white", or possibly Chinese? Wouldn't it be of enormous value if we could create the myth that morality, strong families, determination, courage and love of learning are traits brought by slaves from Mother Africa and therefore quintessentially black?

There is no doubt in mind that most black youngsters could develop their mathematical reasoning, their elocution and their attitudes the way they develop their jump shots and their dance steps: by the combination of sustained, enthusiastic practice and the unquestioned belief that they can do it.

In one sense, what I am talking about is the importance of developing positive ethnic traditions. Maybe Jews have an innate talent for communication; maybe the Chinese are born with a gift for mathematical reasoning; maybe blacks are naturally blessed with athletic grace. I doubt it. What is at work, I suspect, is assumption, inculcated early in their lives, that this is a thing our people do well.

Unfortunately, many of the things about which blacks make this assumption are things that do not contribute to their career success – except for that handful of the truly gifted who can make it as entertainers and athletes. And many of the things we concede to whites are things that are essential to economic security.

So it is with a number of assumptions black youngsters make about what it is to be a "man": physical aggressiveness, sexual prowess, the refusal to submit to authority. The prisons are full of people who, by this perverted definition, are unmistakably men.

But the real problem is not so much that the things defined as "black" are negative. The problem is that the definition is much too narrow.

Somehow, we have to make our children understand that they are intelligent, competent people, capable of doing whatever they put their minds to and making it in the American mainstream, not just in a black subculture.

What we seem to be doing, instead, is raising up yet another generation of young blacks who will be failures – by definition.

Task

a. From your reading of the passage, provide an appropriate title. **(1 mark)**
b. Explain how according to the author, the general use of the term 'black' is limiting where the use of 'white' is not. **(2 marks)**
c. How is 'whiteness' used as an insult by black children? **(2 marks)**
d. Explain one of the main reasons black youngsters do better in sports than white youngsters? **(2 marks)**
e. What assumptions about manhood do some black youngsters make, according to the author? **(2 marks)**

f. The author talks about some of the negative connotations of the term 'black', explain only two of these negative connotations. **(2 marks)**

g. Provide the contextual meaning of the following words or phrases as used in the passage:

(i) Infect **(1 mark)**

(ii) "handicap of definition" **(1 mark)**

(iii) "array of habits and attitudes" **(1mark)**

(iv) "failure by definition" **(1 mark)**

(15 marks)

Question 4

a. Write an opening paragraph of an essay on any topic of your choice. After writing the paragraph, critically explain the function that each sentence contained in the paragraph is performing. **(5 marks)**

b. Explain the role that each of the following part of a long formal report performs:

(i) Transmittal memo or letter **(1 mark)**

(ii) Abstract or Executive Summary **(1 mark)**

(iii) Introduction **(1 mark)**

(iv) Conclusion **(1 mark)**

(v) List of References **(1 mark)**

(10 marks)

END OF QUESTION PAPER